



Skipper on fire: Brazilian forward Raphinha has been the star of the show for Barcelona so far, scoring in all of his side's fixtures and taking his goal tally to six, with an assist to go along with it. AP

Elliot Anderson, Ayyoub Bouaddi and Enzo Fernandez, who was brought in on Deadline Day from Chelsea for a whopping £125 million. The red side of Manchester, meanwhile, has had a topsy-turvy start to its campaign. After a shock defeat against Hull City in the opening week, skipper Bruno Fernandes bagged a hat-trick and an assist as United thumped Ipswich Town to rekindle optimism.

However, it was quickly given a reality check in its next fixture as Everton twice erased United's lead, with Ainsley Maitland-Niles clinching a point for the Toffees with a stunning strike deep into added time.

Another English giant, Liverpool, finally secured its first win under Andoni Iraola after identical 2-2 draws in its first two games. Alexander Isak seems to have joined the party for the Reds, a year after his arrival, scoring

twice off Cody Gakpo's passes to beat newly promoted Ipswich.

The last member of the 'Big Six', Tottenham Hotspur, has fared the worst so far. While exorbitant sums were spent in the summer window to improve on its 17th-place finish last season, Spurs are yet to score a goal, losing 0-2 to Newcastle United before playing out a stalemate against Nottingham Forest.

Hull City, meanwhile, have emerged as an early surprise package in its first English top-flight season after nine years away. The Sergej Jakirovic-coached side beat fellow promoted side Coventry 1-0 before holding Europa League winner Aston Villa to a goalless draw to sit third in the standings. Perhaps more striking, however, is the fact that Hull is the only team yet to concede a goal after three matchdays.

La Liga

At the start of the decade, Barcelona entered a period of transition, bidding farewell to some of the greatest players to wear its colours. The arrival of Hansi Flick in 2024 marked the completion of the rebuild, and two league titles later, the Catalans are showing no signs of slowing down.

They thumped Rayo Vallecano and Valencia 5-2 and 5-0 respectively, hitting the five-goal mark in three of their first four games of the ongoing campaign.

Brazilian forward Raphinha has been the star of the show for Barcelona so far, scoring in all of his side's fixtures and taking his goal tally to six, with an assist to go along with it. Meanwhile, Lamine Yamal, who many — especially rival fans — expected to mellow down after a bright start to his career, has got in on the action for the club with consecutive braces in the last two games.

Barcelona's dominant start will taste even sweeter as its closest rivals, Real Madrid and Atletico Madrid, were both handed disheartening defeats. The latter was punished for its wasted chances by Athletic Club, which managed a 3-0 win thanks to strikes from Nico Williams, Robert Navarro and Oihan Sancet.

Real, perhaps, was taken on a rougher journey by Real Betis. Their meeting remained deadlocked for 80 minutes before substitute Troy Parrott pounced on a loose ball to fire Betis into the lead. Real frantically searched for a response, but fortune deserted it as Carlos Espi's bicycle kick was ruled out for offside, while Kylian Mbappe saw his attempt from the spot saved by Alvaro Valles, who made sure to rub salt into the Frenchman's wound.

Questions were raised about whether Betis defender Marc Bartra had encroached into the box as the penalty was taken, but VAR controversially ruled out any chance of a retake, handing Jose Mourinho the first loss of his second tenure as the boss of Los Blancos.